

World in Brief: Skin-cancer vaccine shows promise; America's government debt passes \$40trn



Photograph: Alamy

Moderna and **Merck**, two American pharma companies, reported successful interim results in the trial of a personalised **skin-cancer vaccine**. The combination of an mRNA jab with an immunotherapy drug already produced by Merck reduced melanoma recurrence. The positive results are the first for a late-stage trial of an [mRNA cancer vaccine](#). Both companies' share prices rose; Moderna's surged by 177%.

America's federal-government debt passed \$40trn for the first time, according to figures published on Wednesday. Earlier, the **Treasury** said it will [buy back more](#) long-term government **bonds** in an attempt to contain borrowing costs. In response, the yield on 30-year Treasuries fell slightly to 5.2%. Investors' worries about inflation and America's huge debt had pushed 30-year yields to their highest since 2007.

Donald Trump said he would meet **Kim Jong Un**, North Korea's dictator, this year. Neither the White House nor the North Korean government confirmed this. This week Mr Trump [scaled back military exercises with South Korea](#), partly because he has a "very good relationship" with Mr Kim. Despite the gesture, [Kim Yo Jong](#),

Mr Kim's sister, said America still has a "hostile policy" towards North Korea.

Israel's military police launched **criminal investigations** into two incidents in which Israel Defence Forces soldiers killed Palestinians in Gaza. In one, in 2024, Hind Rajab, a five-year-old girl, was killed when troops fired on the vehicle carrying her. In another an attack on a convoy of emergency workers in March 2025 left 15 dead. Rights groups have criticised similar investigations for being too lenient.

Volodymyr Zelensky's credibility took another hit as Ukraine's **anti-corruption** agencies said they were investigating staff in the president's office. Mr Zelensky dismissed the deputy head of his office but did not comment. On Tuesday the popular former defence minister, [Mykhailo Fedorov](#), called for elections in a challenge to Mr Zelensky. Elections are suspended under martial law, in effect since Russia's invasion in 2022.

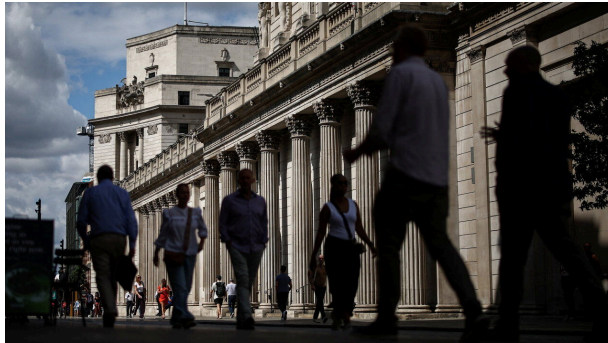
The **United Arab Emirates** halted all commercial and trade relations with **Iran**, accusing the country of firing two ballistic missiles into its territory. Iran denied launching the attack, which would mark its first assault on the [Gulf state](#), one of its biggest trading partners, since May. The incident prompted an emergency phone alert to residents in the UAE.

The **Ebola outbreak** in the Democratic Republic of Congo surpassed 5,000 cases, nearly half of them fatal, according to data from Congo's health ministry. The disease has spread at an [unprecedented rate](#), three times faster than the outbreak in west Africa in 2014 which claimed 11,000 lives. Tedros Adhanom Ghebreyesus, the director-general of the World Health Organisation, described the epidemic as "far from being under control".

Figure of the day: 50, the number of commercial wineries in Sweden. [Read about how](#) a white from the “Nordic Tuscany” beat Europe’s finest to become the wine of choice at the Nobel Prize banquet.

Will Binyamin Netanyahu hold on to power in Israel’s election? See the latest odds and guide to the candidates in our [poll tracker](#).

The Bank of England's inflation conundrum



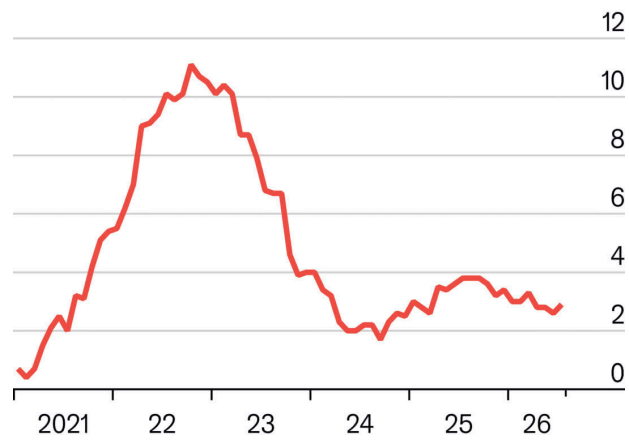
Photograph: Getty Images

Andy Burnham spent much of his first month as Britain's prime minister finding ways to make life's necessities cheaper. But still inflation is heading in the wrong direction. In July it rose by 2.9% year-on-year, up from 2.6% in June. Energy is the main culprit. The government's price cap on electricity and gas bills increased by 13% on July 1st, a result of the Iran war. The Bank of England reckons inflation will peak at 3.2% in November.

Will this nudge the central bank into raising its main interest rate, currently 3.75%, next month? Perhaps not. Core inflation (which excludes volatile energy and food prices) stayed steady in July, helped by temporary tax cuts for summertime visits to theme parks, zoos and other leisure venues. Meanwhile private-sector wage growth continued to slow in June. Rate-setters worry about [high energy costs](#) prompting broader price and wage increases. There are few signs of this so far.

In the foothills

Britain, consumer prices,
% increase on a year earlier



Source: ONS

Ukraine's maritime chokepoint



Photograph: Getty Images

Ukraine's aerial campaign against Russia has inflicted economic damage and [brought the war home](#). But Vladimir Putin's forces have hit back harder. In July Russia launched a record 198 ballistic and hypersonic missiles, mostly at Kyiv, the capital. Ukraine's lack of interceptors forces it to shield only the most high-profile targets. Now Russia is using new tactics to cripple Ukraine's economy.

In the past month Russia has targeted Ukraine's economic lifeline: ships entering and leaving Odessa's ports. The ports were forced to shut early in the war, but reopened in 2023 with a protected corridor. Yet they have been commercially dead since July 19th, when cruise missiles sank a Turkish-owned cargo ship. The timing could hardly be worse, with 50m tonnes of harvest still to move and no clear alternative routes. If this year's [grain](#) can't be sold, farmers are likely to skip the winter sowing season, pushing their losses to \$10bn-12bn. Ukraine desperately needs its Western allies to give it more interceptors.

Hong Kong's stock exchange is back in fashion



Photograph: Reuters

Shein, a fast-fashion giant, is expected to begin taking orders for its initial public offering of shares in Hong Kong this week. The listing will be the latest success for a city that is [regaining](#) its status as a global financial centre. Hong Kong's IPO engine, which was sputtering until recently, is firing on all cylinders. The first half of this year was its best in half a decade. By number of deals and the amount of funds it raised it surpassed New York's main exchange, according to KPMG, a consultancy.

Hong Kong owes much of its [recovery](#) to authorities in Beijing. The China Securities Regulatory Commission has fast-tracked secondary listings of prominent Chinese firms in Hong Kong, prompting a rush of deals. It has also discouraged firms from raising money in Western markets. After American lawmakers stymied Shein's attempt to float in New York, the CSRC delayed its authorisation to list in London, pushing the company towards Hong Kong instead.

A Caledonian revival for Hiawatha



Photograph: Antoine Saito

Samuel Coleridge-Taylor (not to be confused with Samuel Taylor Coleridge) was one of the finest composers of Edwardian Britain. His masterpiece is “The Song of Hiawatha”, three cantatas recounting a Native American epic. Almost every summer between 1924 and 1939 the Royal Albert Hall in London staged a vast performance featuring 1,000 singers and dancers. Audiences lapped up the feathered headdresses and wigwams long before cultural appropriation was a consideration.

After the second world war his choral work was largely forgotten. On Wednesday it will be performed at the Edinburgh International Festival for the first time, and recorded for broadcast on the BBC. Expect the staging to be more modest. “The Song of Hiawatha” has a complicated cultural legacy; Coleridge-Taylor was black, and sold the rights to his composition for a pittance. The latest performance is a gratifying revival for an often overlooked composer.

Daily quiz



Illustration: Sandra Navarro

We will serve you a new question each weekday. On Friday your challenge is to give us all five answers and tell us the theme. Email your responses (and your home city and country) by 1700 BST on Friday to [\[email protected\]](#). We'll pick three winners at random and crown them on Saturday.

Wednesday: Which play by Bertolt Brecht is about a peasant girl who rescues a baby?

Tuesday: What term, familiar from geometry, is used to describe the act of acquiring the bulk of a commodity's supply so as to drive up the price?

*You can no more win a war than
you can win an earthquake.*

Jeannette Rankin